

▲ SHOBHANABEN BARAIYA, *51*
| BJP | ***Sabarkantha, Gujarat***

A school teacher by profession, teaching Gujarati, Hindi and English languages to primary school students at a government school in Gujarat's Sabarkantha, Shobhana opted for voluntary retirement earlier this year. Wife of former Congress MLA Mahendrasinh Baraiya, who joined the BJP in 2022, Shobhana had no political standing till the BJP fielded her from Sabarkantha. The party had earlier nominated VHP veteran Bhikhaji Thakor as its candidate for the seat, but he backed out. While the school teacher's nomination had initially led to protest within the party, the BJP was able to contain it. Shobhana defeated the Congress's Tusharsinh Chaudhari, son of former tribal chief minister Amarsinh Chaudhari, by a margin of 155,682 votes.



ANI

▲ NIMUBEN BAMBHANIYA, *57*
| BJP | ***Bhavnagar, Gujarat***

A two-time mayor of Bhavnagar city, Nimuben has been made a minister of state in Modi 3.0. A member of the Koli community, the most dominant of the OBC communities in Gujarat, Nimuben has studied BSc and BEd, and was a teacher in a private school. A known face in Saurashtra politics, she rose through the party ranks in the past two decades. She has also served as vice president of BJP's state Mahila Morcha. Considered soft-spoken and straightforward, she won by a margin of 455,289 votes over AAP's Umeshbhai Makhwana.



▶ MANOJ TIGGA, *52*
| BJP | ***Alipurduars (ST), West Bengal***

A primary school teacher in Alipurduar district (currently on lien), Tigga is a member of the Oraon tribe and comes from a family of tea plantation labourers. He unsuccessfully contested the West Bengal assembly elections in 2001, 2006, 2011, before finally winning from Madarihat in 2016 and 2021, serving as the BJP's chief whip in the assembly between 2016 and 2024. Onward to a parliamentary stint now, after defeating TMC's Prakash Chik Baraik by 75,447 votes.



▲ JAGADISH CHANDRA BARMA BASUNIA, *60*
| TMC | ***Coochbehar (SC), West Bengal***

A physical education teacher at a school in Coochbehar district, Basunia retired from the post this January. Time therefore to focus solely on his political career, which began from the gram panchayat in Coochbehar district in 1993 and saw him get elected as MLA from Sitai constituency in 2016 and 2021. Now, he has defeated former Union MoS for home affairs—under Amit Shah—Nisith Pramanick.

–Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Jumana Shah, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Aparmita Das